

Diplodocus

dip-LOD-oh-kuss

- **When** 150–145 million years ago (Late Jurassic)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Plains
- **Length** 82 ft (25 m)
- **Diet** Leaves

Diplodocus is the longest dinosaur known from a complete skeleton. It had an incredibly long tail—as long as the rest of its body—which it could move at an amazing speed, creating a whiplike crack. *Diplodocus*'s neck was almost three times the length of a giraffe's neck and was probably held up at a high angle. Its backbone was strong enough to

support its enormous weight, but the bones were hollow. Some scientists think it was a tree-browser, using the peglike teeth at the front of its jaws to strip leaves off branches. Others think it couldn't lift its head high enough and probably swung it from side to side to browse on low shrubs. *Diplodocus* may have grown at a very fast rate, taking around 10 years to become a full-sized adult.



▲ **BONY BRIDGE** To support its long neck and tail, *Diplodocus*'s backbone acted like the cables in a suspension bridge. The cables take the weight of the road (the neck and tail) and pass it down through the piers (the legs), which anchor it to the ground.

Amargasaurus

ah-MAR-gah-SORE-us

- **When** 130 million years ago (Early Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** Argentina
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 36 ft (11 m)
- **Diet** Plants

This relatively small and short-necked diplodocoid was unusual because it had a double row of spines running along its neck and back that became a single line down its tail. There may have been a web of skin running between the spines, forming a double sail. Why it had a sail on its back is a mystery, but perhaps *Amargasaurus* used it for display. Some scientists think it didn't have a sail and simply rattled the spines to make a noise.

▼ GIANT FOOTPRINTS

The Morrison Formation in the US has revealed many bones and footprints of giant diplodocoids such as *Apatosaurus* and *Diplodocus*, along with fossils of the trees and plants they ate.

Apatosaurus

a-PAT-oh-SORE-us

- **When** 150 million years ago (Late Jurassic)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 75 ft (23 m)
- **Diet** Plants

Weighing as much as four elephants, *Apatosaurus* (or *Brontosaurus*, as it is popularly known) was shorter and heavier than its relatives, with thicker legs. Some scientists think that instead of rearing up to feed from trees, *Apatosaurus* may have used its strong limbs and massive weight to knock trees down, as elephants do today. Pencil-like teeth lined the front of its broad muzzle.